

RACoon RESCUE

Written by

Words To Film By

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FADE IN:

1 INT. NAVY JAG COURTROOM - DAY

1

Fluorescent lights. Wood paneling. The sterile formality of military justice.

A COURT REPORTER'S fingers hover over her stenotype. She has typed a lot of things in this room. She has never typed anything like this.

COMMANDER PATRICIA WELLS (50), prosecutor, stands before the bench. Silver oak leaves gleam. Her uniform is immaculate. Her expression suggests she has reviewed this case file multiple times and is still not entirely sure it exists.

COMMANDER WELLS
The prosecution calls its final witness.

ANGLE ON: The witness stand.

PETTY OFFICER FIRST CLASS DANNY VEGA (32) sits in dress whites. The uniform is perfect. The man inside it is not.

A BANDAGE covers his left ear. SCRATCHES rake down his neck, disappearing beneath his collar. His eyes carry the hollow distance of a man who has seen something he cannot unsee.

In the gallery: GERALD (58), in a sport coat that does not fit the occasion. His wife MARGARET clutches his arm. Gerald's jaw works silently, rehearsing testimony he has already given.

Commander Wells approaches a TABLE OF EVIDENCE. She lifts an item with two fingers, as if it might bite.

CLOSE ON: A CLEAR EVIDENCE BAG. Inside: a laminated CARD. White background. Black ink. A perfect RACCOON PAW PRINT, pressed into the center like a signature.

Commander Wells holds it before the court.

COMMANDER WELLS
Prosecution's Exhibit Fourteen.
(beat)
Petty Officer Vega.

She lets the silence work. Danny stares at the paw print. The paw print stares back.

COMMANDER WELLS (CONT'D)
Can you explain to this court how
this came to be logged as--

She consults her notes. Reads verbatim.

COMMANDER WELLS (CONT'D)
--"Emergency Override - Wildlife
Incident"?

The court reporter's fingers freeze above the keys.

Gerald leans forward. Margaret's grip tightens.

Danny's mouth opens. Closes. Opens again.

Nothing comes out.

COMMANDER WELLS (CONT'D)
(quieter now)
Take your time, Petty Officer.

Danny looks at the paw print. At the scratches on his hands. At the bandage on his ear.

He looks at the window, where afternoon light falls in bars across the floor.

DANNY
(barely audible)
It started with a letter.

HARD CUT TO BLACK.

TITLE CARD:

R A C O O N R E S C U E

The title holds.

Silence.

Then, faint: the CHITTER of a raccoon, somewhere in the darkness.

FADE TO:

2 INT. BENNIGAN'S-TYPE CHAIN RESTAURANT - NIGHT

2

SUPER: "14 HOURS EARLIER"

Fluorescent lights hum. The kind of green-tinged glow that makes everyone look like they died three days ago.

BIRTHDAY STREAMERS sag from the ceiling, crepe paper curling in the stale air conditioning. A deflated balloon reads "OVER THE HILL" in faded gold. The party ended hours ago.

At the bar: PETTY OFFICER FIRST CLASS DANNY VEGA (32). Not sloppy drunk. Functioning drunk. The dangerous kind. Spine straight. Jaw set. Eyes focused on absolutely nothing.

Eight rocks glasses line up in front of him like little soldiers. Two still have ice melting.

LEON (60s), the bartender, wipes down the already-clean bar. He has the face of a man who has seen everything and expects nothing. He watches Danny like a nature documentary.

The restaurant is otherwise empty. Chairs upended on tables. A BUSBOY mops near the entrance.

LEON
Closing in ten, Chief.

Danny doesn't look up. His thumb and forefinger rub together. Unconscious. A welder checking for burns that aren't there.

DANNY
One more.

LEON
Kitchen's cold.

DANNY
Don't want food.

Leon pours. Jameson. Three fingers. Doesn't charge for it. Doesn't say anything about it either.

Danny's ancient FLIP PHONE sits on the bar, screen dark. He picks it up. Tries to turn it on. Nothing.

DANNY (CONT'D)
Shit.

He stares at the dead phone. Then shakes it like that helps.

DANNY (CONT'D)
(to Leon)
You got a charger? The old kind?

LEON
Ain't had one of those since Bush.

Danny nods. Accepts this. Takes a long pull of whiskey.

CLOSE ON: The phone's blank screen. Before it died, the contact list was visible. A name: "SPONSOR MIKE - DO NOT ANSWER AFTER 2100."

He never called.

Danny reaches for his wallet. Worn leather. Navy Federal card. He hands it to Leon.

Leon runs it. Waits. The MACHINE BEEPS. Wrong kind of beep.

LEON (CONT'D)
Declined.

DANNY
Run it again.

Leon runs it again. Same beep.

LEON
Same answer.

Danny's jaw tightens. He exhales through his nose.

DANNY
I got another one somewhere--

He pats his pockets. Comes up with: keys, a Copenhagen can, Rachel's letter. No second card. He stares at the letter for a moment, then shoves it back.

DANNY (CONT'D)
I can come back tomorrow. First thing.

LEON
(shrugging)
It's handled.

He takes the eight empty glasses and the full one. Starts washing. Doesn't look at Danny.

LEON (CONT'D)
I put it on your tab.

Danny doesn't have a tab. They both know this.

DANNY
I appreciate that.

LEON
Mm-hm.

Danny stands. Steady. Careful. The practiced stability of a man who has done this too many times.

He picks up his KEYS. Holds them a moment.

CLOSE ON: The key ring. A BREATHALYZER DEVICE - the portable IID interlock handset - dangles from it. Small camera lens visible. There's also an AA CHIP. Bronze. Six months.

Danny looks at the chip. Looks away.

He starts for the door. Passes the birthday decorations. A HELIUM BALLOON has sunk to eye level, string dragging on the floor. "40 AND FABULOUS."

He walks around it.

LEON (CONT'D)
You got a ride, Chief?

Danny stops. Doesn't turn around.

DANNY
I got a truck.

A beat. Leon keeps washing glasses.

LEON
Drive safe.

Danny pushes through the door.

Leon watches him go. Sets down the glass. Picks up his own phone. Looks at it.

Does not dial.

He goes back to wiping the bar. The same spot. Over and over.

LEON (CONT'D)
(quiet, to no one)
Yeah. You got a truck.

He turns off the neon signs. One by one. The room goes dark except for the exit sign's red glow.

3 EXT. BENNIGAN'S-TYPE CHAIN RESTAURANT - PARKING LOT - NIGHT 3

1:47 AM. Sodium vapor lights cast everything in harsh orange. The kind of light that makes shadows look solid.

Danny walks across the empty lot. His boots echo on asphalt.

His TRUCK waits at the far end. 2009 Ford F-150. Silver. Paint oxidizing. Check engine light probably on.

He walks past a MINIVAN with a "HONOR STUDENT" bumper sticker.

Past a MOTORCYCLE chained to a pole.

Past a DUMPSTER.

Something RUSTLES inside.

Danny doesn't stop. Keeps walking.

He reaches the truck. Keys out. The IID device catches the orange light.

He stares at it.

DANNY
(to himself)
It's fine.

He unlocks the door. Climbs in.

4 INT. DANNY'S TRUCK - CONTINUOUS

4

Danny settles into the driver's seat. The cab smells like Copenhagen and old coffee. Empty cups crowd the console - spit cups. The car seat in back, never used, still has tags.

He plugs his dead phone into the dash charger. Muscle memory. The screen flickers to life.

He puts the key in the ignition. Doesn't turn it.

He looks at the IID handset. The camera stares back.

DANNY
Okay.

He picks up the handset. Positions it. Takes a breath.

Blows.

The device BEEPS. Red light.

IID DISPLAY: "BAC .14 - FAIL - LOCKOUT ACTIVE"

Danny stares at the readout.

DANNY (CONT'D)
Okay.

His head drops back against the headrest.

DANNY (CONT'D)
(to the ceiling)
It's fine. This is fine.

He sits in the dark. The orange light cuts through the windshield in stripes.

Through the glass, in the distance: the dumpster.

Something MOVES.

Danny's eyes track to it. Slowly.

Two reflective points of light. Eyes. Watching him.

Then gone.

Danny doesn't move for a long moment.

DANNY (CONT'D)
(very quiet)
This is fine.

He opens the truck door.

5 EXT. BENNIGAN'S-TYPE CHAIN RESTAURANT - PARKING LOT - 5
CONTINUOUS

Danny walks toward the light. Gravel crunches under boots that don't quite track straight.

The dumpster looms larger as he approaches. The sodium vapor light illuminates it from above.

The effect is almost religious. A garbage cathedral. The dumpster glows like something holy, something meant to be found.

The lid is cracked open. Something RUSTLES inside.

Danny stops three feet away. Peers over the edge.

6 EXT. DUMPSTER - DANNY'S POV - CONTINUOUS 6

Among the garbage, belly-up, surrounded by fast food debris and fermenting vegetables:

A RACCOON.

Fat. Unconscious. One tiny paw TWITCHES occasionally--the only sign of life. Its belly rises and falls with the slow rhythm of the profoundly food-drunk.

The sodium vapor light catches its fur. Makes it glow. A creature of the garbage, transformed by circumstance into something almost beautiful.

7 EXT. BENNIGAN'S-TYPE CHAIN RESTAURANT - PARKING LOT - 7
CONTINUOUS

Danny stares down at the raccoon.

The raccoon's paw twitches again. Then stillness.

Danny looks back at his truck. At the breathalyzer waiting inside. At the red light that said no.

He looks down at the raccoon. At its small chest. Rising. Falling. Rising. Falling.

Breathing.

CLOSE ON: Danny's face.

We watch it happen in real time. The worst idea of his life, born in the orange glow of a parking lot at midnight.

His brow furrows. His eyes narrow. The corner of his mouth twitches--not quite a smile, but something adjacent to one.

Recognition.

His head tilts. His lips part.

And there it is: the EUREKA. The terrible, beautiful eureka of a drunk man who has just solved an unsolvable problem.

Danny straightens up. Looks down at the raccoon with new eyes.

No longer a creature. A tool. A solution. A way out.

DANNY
(quietly, almost reverent)
You breathe.

He reaches down.

FADE TO:

8 EXT. DUMPSTER - MOMENTS LATER

8

Danny straightens up. Squares his shoulders. The drunk sway in his stance steadies into something else.

Purpose.

He circles the dumpster. Slow. Measured. A predator assessing terrain. Three steps left. Pause. Listen. Three steps right.

His eyes sweep the perimeter. The back door of the restaurant: closed. The parking lot: empty. The distant highway: cars passing, indifferent, their headlights sweeping the tree line.

Danny stops. Reaches down. Picks up a PEBBLE.

He weighs it in his palm. Rolls it between his fingers.

Tosses it into the dumpster.

PLINK.

He waits.

Nothing. No movement. No chittering. Just the slow rhythm of a belly rising and falling among the trash.

Danny nods. Good recon.

He moves to his TRUCK. Opens the door. Pulls out a WORK JACKET--heavy canvas, the kind meant for welding or crawling under engines.

He shrugs it on. Buttons it to the collar.

Rolls up the sleeves. Once. Twice. Tight against his forearms.

Flexes his fingers. Cracks his knuckles.

The gesture is ridiculous. The execution is flawless.

He approaches the dumpster again. Stops at the edge. Places both hands on the rim.

LOW ANGLE: Danny peers over the edge into darkness. The sodium vapor light catches his face from below. He looks like a man about to defuse a bomb.

DANNY
(under his breath)
Okay. Okay.

He looks left. Right. Back at the dumpster.

DANNY (CONT'D)
Easy.

He pulls himself up. Swings one leg over. Then the other.

He DISAPPEARS into the dumpster.

**9 EXT. BENNIGAN'S-TYPE CHAIN RESTAURANT - PARKING LOT - WIDE 9
SHOT - CONTINUOUS**

The dumpster sits in its pool of orange light. Silent.

Then:

DANNY (O.S.)
(muffled)
Oh god.

A CLANG from inside. Something shifts.

DANNY (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Oh god what is that smell--

More shifting. The dumpster ROCKS slightly on its wheels.

DANNY (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Okay. Okay okay okay--

Silence.

A long beat.

DANNY (O.S.) (CONT'D)
(barely audible)
Come here. Come here, buddy.

The dumpster lid BANGS open.

DANNY emerges.

He stands in the dumpster, cradling something against his chest. Both arms wrapped around it. Protective. Tender.

THE RACCOON.

It hangs limp in his arms. Fat belly. Tiny paws dangling. A smear of something--ketchup? barbecue sauce?--across its fur.

Danny's face is RADIANT. The joy of a man who has done something impossible. Who has solved the unsolvable. Who has stolen fire from the gods.

He climbs out of the dumpster. One leg, then the other. Careful. So careful. Like the creature in his arms might shatter.

Something DRIPS from his jacket. He does not look down.

He walks toward the truck. His gait has changed. No longer the swagger of a drunk. The measured steps of a man carrying precious cargo.

10 EXT. DANNY'S TRUCK - CONTINUOUS

10

Danny reaches the driver's side door. Looks down at the raccoon. At his arms, full of sleeping wildlife.

He cannot open the door.

He stands there. Calculating. Processing. Too drunk to have planned this far ahead.

Slowly, he shifts the raccoon to one arm. Cradles it like a football. Reaches for the door handle--

The raccoon STIRS.

Danny FREEZES.

The world stops. The sodium lights hum. A car passes on the distant highway, its headlights sweeping across nothing.

The raccoon's nose TWITCHES. One paw flexes. Relaxes.

Its eyes stay closed.

Danny does not breathe.

One second. Two. Three.

The raccoon's head lolls. It settles deeper into the crook of his arm. Returns to its garbage coma.

Danny exhales.

He YANKS the door open. THROWS himself into the truck. Pulls the door shut with his elbow. All in one motion. Explosive. Desperate.

11 INT. DANNY'S TRUCK - CONTINUOUS

11

Dashboard glow. The world outside has shrunk to nothing. Only this matters: Danny, the raccoon, and the machine.

Danny sits behind the wheel. In his lap: the RACCOON. Still unconscious. Still breathing. Still the worst idea he's ever had.

The BREATHALYZER INTERLOCK DEVICE waits on the steering column. Red LED. Patient. Unblinking.

Danny lifts the raccoon toward the mouthpiece. Its head lolls. Its tongue hangs out. It looks dead. It is not dead. Probably.

He holds the raccoon's face near the device.

Nothing happens.

DANNY

Come on.

He adjusts his grip. Tries again. Positions the small snout directly in front of the mouthpiece.

The raccoon's whiskers twitch. That's it.

DANNY (CONT'D)

Come on, buddy. Breathe for me.

Danny's voice is gentle. Coaxing. The voice you use for a child, or a dying pet, or a wild animal you've stolen from a dumpster to commit fraud.

He waits.

The red LED pulses. Waiting for input.

The raccoon does not provide input.

Danny's jaw tightens. He shifts the animal, cradles it like a baby. Its little arms dangle. Its little face reveals nothing.

DANNY (CONT'D)

Okay. Okay.

He reaches up with one hand. Opens the raccoon's mouth manually. Tiny teeth. A surprising amount of tiny teeth. He positions the open mouth toward the device.

Holds.

Waits.

The raccoon's chest rises. Falls. But nothing comes out of the mouth. Wrong angle. Wrong everything.

Danny pulls back. Stares at the animal. The animal stares at nothing, because it is unconscious.

DANNY (CONT'D)

(to himself)

Think. Think.

He looks at the raccoon's chest. Watches it rise. Fall. Rise. Fall. There's air in there. He just needs to get it out.

Danny positions the raccoon again. One hand supporting its back. The other hand hovering over its belly.

He places his palm on the small chest. Feels the heartbeat through the fur. Faster than expected. Alive.

DANNY (CONT'D)

Sorry about this.

He squeezes. Gently. Like a bellows. Like CPR for the morally compromised.

A tiny puff of air escapes the raccoon's mouth.

Danny's eyes go wide.

He repositions. Mouthpiece closer. Much closer.

Squeezes again.

PUFF.

The device BEEPS.

Danny freezes.

CLOSE ON: The IID screen.

Processing...

The moment stretches. The universe holds its breath because Danny certainly cannot.

GREEN LIGHT.

The LED shifts. Red to green. The most beautiful color Danny has ever seen.

ENGINE AUTHORIZED appears on the tiny screen.

12 INT. DANNY'S TRUCK - CONTINUOUS

12

Danny stares at the green light. At the raccoon. At the green light again.

DANNY
Holy shit.

Beat.

DANNY (CONT'D)
(louder, wonder breaking
through)
Holy shit it worked.

He laughs. The sound is wrong--too loud, too sharp, the laugh of a man who cannot believe what he has done and knows he will have to live with it.

The raccoon twitches in his lap. One paw. Then stillness.

Danny looks down at it. His accomplice. His co-conspirator. His tiny, unconscious partner in crime.

DANNY (CONT'D)
Okay. Okay, we're good. We're good.

He starts the engine. It RUMBLES to life. A small miracle.

Danny shifts the raccoon off his lap. Places it on the passenger seat. It slumps against the door. Begins to slide.

Danny catches it.

He looks at the raccoon. At the seat. At the seatbelt.

The math takes a moment. The conclusion is inevitable.

13 INT. DANNY'S TRUCK - CONTINUOUS**13**

Danny reaches across. Grabs the SEATBELT. Pulls it over the unconscious raccoon.

CLICK.

The raccoon is now buckled in. Passenger seat. Shoulder strap across its furry chest. Lap belt somewhere around its belly. Head lolled to one side. Paws limp.

It looks like a very small, very drunk, very unconscious person heading home from a party that got out of hand.

THE HERO SHOT:

Wide on the truck cab. Danny behind the wheel, scratches on his hands, sweat on his brow. The unconscious raccoon buckled into the passenger seat like a tiny, furry designated driver who has failed at its one job.

The green light of the IID glows on the dashboard. Reflected in Danny's eyes. In the windshield. In the future that should not exist but somehow does.

Danny looks at the raccoon. The raccoon does not look back.

DANNY

It's fine.

(beat)

This is fine.

He says it differently this time. Not panic. Not denial. Relief. Pure, unearned, impossible relief.

Danny puts the truck in gear.

He drives.

The raccoon rides shotgun into the night.

FADE TO:

14 INT. DANNY'S TRUCK (MOVING) - NIGHT**14**

The road unspools ahead. Empty. 2 AM quiet.

Streetlights strobe through the windshield at regular intervals. Light. Dark. Light. Dark. Each one paints Danny's face in orange, then shadow.

His hands grip the wheel at ten and two. Textbook. The grip of a man proving he is in control.

The IID handset hangs from the steering column. Green light glowing. Victory.

In the passenger seat: the RACCOON. Seatbelt stretched across its belly. Eyes closed. One paw curled against its chest like a sleeping child.

Its chest rises. Falls. Rises. Falls.

Danny glances at it. Then back at the road.

Then at it again.

DANNY
(quiet, almost to himself)
Holy shit.

He laughs. Short. Surprised. The sound of a man who cannot believe what he just did.

DANNY (CONT'D)
It actually worked.

He shakes his head. Looks at the raccoon again.

DANNY (CONT'D)
Hey. Hey, buddy. You did good.

The raccoon does not respond. Its chest rises. Falls.

DANNY (CONT'D)
Real good. You're a hero. Gonna get you back to your... dumpster, or wherever. Soon as I get home. Thirty minutes, tops.

Silence. The engine hums. The streetlights strobe.

Danny's thumbs tap the steering wheel. Nervous energy looking for an exit.

DANNY (CONT'D)
Rachel would've loved this.

A beat. He wasn't expecting that to come out.

DANNY (CONT'D)
My wife. Ex-wife. Soon to be. Still technically... it's complicated.

He glances at the raccoon like it might judge him.

It doesn't. It can't. That's the point.

DANNY (CONT'D)
She left four months ago. Probably should've left earlier. I would've left earlier if I was her.

The truck passes under a streetlight. Orange wash. Danny's face in sharp relief.

DANNY (CONT'D)
You know what's funny? I didn't even fight it. She said she was leaving and I said okay. Just... okay. Didn't yell. Didn't beg. Didn't do any of the things you're supposed to do.

He rubs his thumb and forefinger together. The welder's tic.

DANNY (CONT'D)
I just watched her pack.

Another streetlight. Dark. Light. Dark.

DANNY (CONT'D)
She wrote me a letter. Sent it three weeks later. I've read it maybe twenty times. Can't finish it. Every time I get to the part where she says... where she says she was scared of me...

His voice catches. He clears his throat.

DANNY (CONT'D)
I punched a door. Once. Came home from the bar, couldn't find my keys, and I just... punched the door frame. Broke two knuckles. She was inside. She heard.

He looks at his right hand on the wheel. The knuckles still slightly swollen.

DANNY (CONT'D)
She wasn't scared I'd hurt her. She knew I wouldn't. She was scared of what I was becoming. That's worse, you know? That's so much worse.

The raccoon's paw twitches. Just reflexive. Danny doesn't notice.

DANNY (CONT'D)
I have these... attacks. Since 2012. Heart racing, can't breathe, feel like I'm dying. Rachel was the only one who knew. She'd hold my hand and tell me to count backwards from a
(MORE)

DANNY (CONT'D)
hundred. By the time I got to sixty
it was usually over.

He swallows.

DANNY (CONT'D)
I haven't had anyone to count with
in four months.

A long pause. The road stretches ahead. Endless.

DANNY (CONT'D)
You know what I miss? I miss being
small. I miss being twelve years old
and not knowing how to fix anything
and that being okay. That being
allowed.

He stares at the road.

DANNY (CONT'D)
Now everything's my fault. If it
breaks, I should've prevented it.
If it fails, I should've seen it
coming. If she leaves...

He can't finish.

The raccoon's paw twitches again. Slightly longer this
time. Danny still doesn't notice.

DANNY (CONT'D)
I'm telling all this to a raccoon.

He laughs. Not funny. Real.

DANNY (CONT'D)
An unconscious raccoon that I found
in a dumpster. That I strapped into
my passenger seat. That I used to
beat a breathalyzer so I could drive
drunk for the second time in six
months.

Beat.

DANNY (CONT'D)
That's who I am. That's the guy
Rachel left. That's the guy who
couldn't make Chief. That's the
guy who punches doors.

He grips the wheel tighter.

DANNY (CONT'D)
 And I still can't call Mike. Even
 now. Even after all of it. I still
 can't pick up the phone and say--

His voice breaks.

DANNY (CONT'D)
 I need help.

The words hang in the cab. First time he has ever said
 them out loud. To anyone. Even a raccoon.

The streetlights strobe.

Danny wipes his face again. Sets his jaw. Stares ahead.

DANNY (CONT'D)
 (quieter now)
 It's fine.

But it sounds different now. Hollow. Even he doesn't
 believe it anymore.

DANNY (CONT'D)
 This is fine.

CLOSE ON: The raccoon's face.

Peaceful. Still.

Then--

The tiniest flicker behind closed eyelids.

HOLD ON this image. The calm before.

Danny doesn't see it. He's watching the road.

DANNY (CONT'D)
 (almost to himself)
 Almost home.

The raccoon's ear twitches.

15 INT. DANNY'S TRUCK (MOVING) - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS

15

Danny reaches for the radio dial.

DANNY
 (trailing off from
 confession)
 ...almost home.

His fingers brush the knob.

CLOSE ON: The raccoon's face.

Its eyes are OPEN.

Not drowsy. Not confused. WIDE. ALERT. LOCKED on Danny's hand as it passes six inches from its snout.

The raccoon's head TRACKS the movement. Smooth. Mechanical. A targeting system acquiring.

Danny doesn't see. He's watching the road.

His hand returns to the wheel.

The raccoon's eyes follow.

ANGLE ON: Danny.

He glances over. Casual. Just checking on--

His face FREEZES.

For a half-second, neither moves. Man and animal. Locked in mutual recognition.

DANNY

Oh--

The raccoon LAUNCHES.

No warning. No transition. One frame still, the next: AIRBORNE.

CLAWS rake across Danny's face. He SCREAMS--a raw, animal sound ripped from somewhere primal. Blood sprays the windshield.

The truck SWERVES.

DANNY (CONT'D)

NO NO NO NO--

He grabs the raccoon. Hurls it against the passenger window. The thing BOUNCES back, scrabbling across the dashboard, knocking papers everywhere.

16 EXT. HIGHWAY - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS

16

WIDE ON: The truck careening across lanes. Brake lights painting the asphalt red.

Inside the cab: SILHOUETTES THRASHING. A nightmare shadow-puppet show.

17 INT. DANNY'S TRUCK (MOVING) - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS

17

Danny holds the wheel with one hand. The other SWATS at the raccoon as it scrambles up his chest.

DANNY
GET OFF GET OFF--

The raccoon's CLAWS find his shoulder. Dig in. Use him as a ladder.

It's going for his FACE again.

Danny throws his head back. The raccoon's teeth SNAP shut on empty air, inches from his nose.

The horn BLARES as his elbow hits it.

The raccoon SCREAMS.

Not a chitter. Not a hiss. A SCREAM. High-pitched. Almost human. The sound of something that should not exist wearing the body of something that does.

The truck jumps the center line.

HEADLIGHTS fill the windshield. HORN blaring from oncoming--

Danny YANKS the wheel. The truck fishtails. Tires SHRIEK against asphalt.

The raccoon loses its grip. Tumbles into the footwell.

One second. Maybe two.

Danny GASPS. Blood runs into his eyes. He can barely see. His hand finds the door handle--

The raccoon EXPLODES from below.

It clamps onto his forearm. Teeth SINK DEEP. Danny watches, horrified, as the thing's jaw LOCKS. It hangs from his arm like a furry anchor.

He SLAMS his arm against the door. Once. Twice. The raccoon holds.

The truck drifts. Danny hauls the wheel with his free hand. Overcorrects. The vehicle bucks.

DANNY
FUCK--

He hammers the brakes.

The raccoon FLIES forward. Hits the windshield. CRACKS the glass in a spiderweb pattern.

Drops to the dashboard.

ANGLE ON: The raccoon.

It rises. Slowly. Deliberately.

Its fur is matted with blood--Danny's blood. Its eyes never leave his face. One ear bent wrong from the impact.

It looks WRONG. Broken but still running. A machine that will not stop.

Danny's chest heaves. Blood drips from his chin onto his uniform. His left eye is swelling shut.

The raccoon takes a step toward him.

Danny's hand finds the door handle.

The raccoon COILS.

18 INT./EXT. DANNY'S TRUCK (CAREENING) - NIGHT

18

The windshield is a smear of BLOOD and FUR. Danny can't see.

The raccoon is ON HIS FACE. Claws dig into his scalp. That UNHOLY SCREAM fills the cab - part woman, part power tool, pure rage.

Danny throws an elbow. Misses. Hits the rearview mirror. Glass SHATTERS.

DANNY
GET OFF--

The wheel jerks LEFT. The truck JUMPS the curb.

Through the chaos, a GLIMPSE: houses with lights on. Music. A wooden fence decorated with PAPER LANTERNS.

The raccoon's teeth find Danny's ear. TEAR into cartilage.

Danny SCREAMS.

His hands leave the wheel entirely.

19 EXT. RESIDENTIAL STREET - OCEANVIEW ESTATES - CONTINUOUS

19

The truck rockets across a manicured lawn. Sprinkler heads EXPLODE under the tires.

A GARDEN GNOME goes flying.

The fence looms. White picket. Decorated with TIKI TORCHES and a banner:

"HAPPY 50TH MARGARET!"

20 EXT. GERALD'S BACKYARD - CONTINUOUS**20**

PARTY IN FULL SWING.

Thirty people. String lights everywhere. A FOLDING TABLE set up for BEER PONG, surrounded by COLLEGE KIDS in backwards caps.

MARGARET (50) stands near a sheet cake, laughing with her book club.

A DJ booth. Music thumping. RED SOLO CUPS everywhere.

GERALD (58) emerges from the sliding door carrying a fresh bag of ice. He wears a Hawaiian shirt that was clearly Margaret's idea.

GIRL AT PONG TABLE
--okay but you have to BOUNCE it--

And then:

SOUND. Like the world tearing.

Everyone's head turns toward the fence.

21 EXT. GERALD'S FENCE - CONTINUOUS**21**

The truck EXPLODES through the white picket barrier.

SLOW MOTION:

Fence posts CARTWHEEL through the air. Paper lanterns scatter like frightened birds. A tiki torch spirals, trailing fire.

The truck's headlights cut through the party smoke like the eyes of a demon.

22 EXT. GERALD'S BACKYARD - CONTINUOUS**22**

NORMAL SPEED.

The truck PLOWS through the beer pong table.

RED SOLO CUPS launch into the air like confetti. Beer sprays in a golden arc. The ping pong balls scatter.

COLLEGE KIDS dive in every direction.

The truck finally STOPS - front bumper six inches from the kidney-shaped pool. Steam hisses from the hood. One headlight still working, casting a single beam across the water.

For THREE FULL SECONDS:

Silence.

Nobody moves.

The DJ's music keeps playing. Something upbeat. Obscene in context.

Every person in the backyard stares at the truck.

23 INT. DANNY'S TRUCK - CONTINUOUS

23

Danny sits behind the wheel.

His face is a HORROR SHOW. Blood streams from his reopened ear. Fresh scratches crosshatch his cheeks. His shirt is torn, revealing more wounds on his chest and shoulder.

He breathes. In. Out.

On the passenger seat, the raccoon sits perfectly still. They lock eyes.

Beat.

BANDIT scrambles up and over the headrest. Danny flinches, but the raccoon has somewhere to be. It squeezes through the shattered rear window and disappears into the night.

Danny watches it go.

He doesn't try to stop it.

24 EXT. GERALD'S BACKYARD - CONTINUOUS

24

The party-goers remain frozen. Then:

FRAT BRO #1
What the FUCK?

This breaks the spell.

FRAT BRO #2
(to anyone with a phone)
Are you recording? RECORD THIS!

PHONES come out. A dozen. More. The SCREENS light up like fireflies.

A GIRL starts screaming - delayed shock. Her friend tries to calm her.

Someone's DAD pulls people back from the truck.

Margaret stands by her ruined cake, mouth open, sheet of frosting splattered across her blouse.

ANGLE ON: The truck cab.

Danny is visible through the driver's window. The lone headlight illuminates him like a spotlight.

Blood. Scratches. Dress whites visible beneath his torn jacket.

THE THOUSAND-YARD STARE.

Around him, PHONE FLASHES pop. Multiple angles. Different heights. He is being recorded from every direction.

Danny just sits there. Doesn't move. Doesn't speak.

Done. Finished. A man who has finally hit bottom.

ANGLE ON: Gerald.

The bag of ice has DROPPED. Cubes scatter across the patio.

Gerald walks toward the destruction in a daze. He passes:

- The decimated beer pong table
- His shattered fence
- His wife's ruined birthday banner

He stops at the driver's side door.

Looks through the window at Danny.

Danny looks back.

GERALD

What in the--
(no words sufficient)
WHAT IS--

Danny's voice is barely audible. Hoarse. Defeated.

DANNY

...sorry.

Gerald blinks. Processes. His eyes drop to Danny's chest. To the torn jacket. To what's visible underneath:

The DRESS WHITE UNIFORM. Navy insignia.

Gerald's face changes. This isn't a random drunk. This is MILITARY.

He looks back at his destroyed backyard. At the phones still recording. At his wife, crying now.

GERALD
 (to himself, almost
 wondering)
 My wife left me for her tennis
 instructor.
 (beat)
 I just wanted one quiet year.

He stares at Danny. Danny stares back.

Neither man has anything else to say.

ANGLE ON: The tree line at the back of the property.

TWO GLOWING EYES watch from the darkness.

BANDIT sits in the branches. Unbothered. Grooming a paw.

He CHITTERS once - it sounds almost like laughter - and
 disappears into the night.

BACK TO: DANNY IN THE TRUCK.

In the distance, the first SIREN wails.

RED SOLO CUPS litter the destroyed lawn like spent shell
 casings.

The DJ finally kills the music. The silence is worse.

Danny closes his eyes.

DANNY (V.O.)
 (barely a whisper)
 It's fine.

He opens his eyes. Looks at the phones. At the
 destruction. At the life he's just ended.

DANNY (V.O.)
 This is...

He can't finish it. For the first time, he can't say the
 words.

He just sits there.

Waiting.

25 EXT. GERALD'S BACKYARD - MOMENTS LATER

25

WIDER SHOT now. The full scope of destruction visible.

The truck sits at a crooked angle, one headlight still
 burning.

Party guests cluster in groups, phones still out.

Gerald stands next to Danny's door like a man who has no idea what to do next.

Margaret has been led inside by friends.

And Danny Vega, Petty Officer First Class, eleven years of service, remains motionless in the cab.

Not fighting it anymore.

The first RED AND BLUE LIGHTS appear on the street beyond the ruined fence.

He doesn't even look.

26 EXT. GERALD'S BACKYARD - CRASH SITE - NIGHT

26

Blue and red lights pulse across the wreckage. The colors wash over everything in slow, hypnotic waves. Police. Ambulance. Fire truck. The full machinery of consequence.

Danny's truck sits nose-first into the hedge near the pool. Steam rises from the crumpled hood. The driver's door hangs open.

CHAOS everywhere:

- PARTY-GOERS spill onto lawns, phones raised, recording everything
- FIREFIGHTERS spray foam on something hissing under Danny's hood
- A PARAMEDIC tends to MARGARET in the back of an ambulance, a blanket around her shoulders
- GERALD stands with TWO COPS, gesturing wildly, pointing at Danny, at the truck, at the sky

And in the middle of it all:

DANNY.

He sits on the curb. Hands in his lap. Completely still.

The world spins around him in blue and red strobe, but Danny has stopped moving. For the first time all night, for the first time in months, maybe for the first time in years--

He is not trying to fix anything.

CLOSE ON: Danny's hands.

His fingers rest on his knees. No movement. No welder's tic. No thumb rubbing against forefinger, checking for burns that are not there.

Just stillness.

ANGLE ON: Danny's face.

Blood runs from a cut above his eyebrow. Scratches rake down his cheek--raccoon's last gift. His eyes are wet. Not crying, exactly. Leaking. The overflow of a container finally allowed to be full.

HIGH ANGLE - looking down on Danny.

He is SMALL in frame. A man surrounded by the machinery of his own destruction. Fire trucks and police cars and gawking strangers with their phones. The chaos he created, spread out around him like evidence.

He does not look up.

A UNIFORMED COP approaches. Young. Clipboard in hand. He crouches to Danny's level.

COP

Sir? Sir, are you injured?

Danny doesn't answer immediately. He looks at his hands. At the blood on his fingers. At the lights painting everything red, then blue, then red again.

COP (CONT'D)

Sir? Can you hear me?

DANNY

(quiet)

Yeah.

COP

Are you injured?

A beat. Danny's jaw works. This is the moment. The old Danny would say: I'm fine. The old Danny would deflect, minimize, insist he had it under control.

DANNY

(barely above a whisper)

Yeah. Yeah, I think so.

The cop nods. Writes something on his clipboard.

COP

Okay. We're going to get you looked at. Just stay right here.

The cop moves away. Danny stays.

In the background, GERALD's voice rises, indistinct. Angry. Margaret says something to calm him. It doesn't work.

Danny doesn't react. He watches the lights pulse.

INSERT - DANNY'S LAP:

His PHONE lies on the asphalt beside him. Cracked screen. Spider-web fractures across the display.

But visible through the damage, glowing faintly:

RECENT CALLS
SPONSOR MIKE - DO NOT ANSWER AFTER
2100

Danny looks at it. Looks away.

Looks back.

He reaches down. Picks up the phone. Holds it like something fragile. Something that might still work.

CLOSE ON: Danny's face.

He doesn't dial. Not yet. But he holds the phone. And for the first time, he doesn't put it away.

He doesn't say: It's fine.

He doesn't say: This is fine.

He doesn't say anything at all.

He just sits there. Present. Still. A man who has finally stopped running from the thing that was always going to catch him.

The blue and red lights wash over his face.

His eyes close.

MATCH CUT TO:

27 INT. NAVY JAG COURTROOM - DAY

27

Danny's eyes open.

Same face. Cleaned up now. The scratches have healed to faint lines. The bandage on his ear is fresh. The dress whites are immaculate.

But the stillness remains.

COMMANDER WELLS (O.S.)
Petty Officer Vega?

Danny blinks. Returns to the present. To the witness stand. To the weight of everything that happened.

COMMANDER WELLS
Are you ready to continue?

Danny looks at the paw print in the evidence bag. At Gerald in the gallery. At his own hands, folded in his lap.

Still.

DANNY
Yes, ma'am.

He takes a breath.

DANNY (CONT'D)
I am now.

28 INT. NAVY JAG COURTROOM - LATER

28

CLOSE ON: Danny's face.

The same face. The same eyes. But different now. The scratches have faded to thin white lines. Scars that will never fully disappear. Marks of something that actually happened.

Danny stands at attention. Dress whites. Collar hiding most of the damage. What shows only makes him look more human.

COMMANDER WELLS
Petty Officer Vega.

WIDER: The courtroom. Same fluorescent lights. Same wood paneling. Same sterile formality we saw in the cold open.

But now we know what led here. Every choice. Every failure. Every moment of a night that should not have happened.

Commander Wells stands before him. Her expression has shifted from incredulity to something closer to exhaustion. She has heard it all now. She still does not quite believe it.

COMMANDER WELLS (CONT'D)
The court has reviewed the evidence.
Your testimony. The...
documentation.

She glances at the evidence table. The laminated card with the paw print. Prosecution's Exhibit Fourteen. It sits there like an accusation with tiny fingers.

COMMANDER WELLS (CONT'D)
Do you have anything to say before
sentencing?

IN THE GALLERY:

Gerald sits rigid. Sport coat. Wrong tie. His jaw works the way it does when he is trying not to speak. Trying not to fix something that cannot be fixed.

Margaret's hand finds his. Squeezes.

Gerald's eyes are wet. He knows what is coming. He has known since the letter arrived. Since before that, maybe. Since the first time Danny said "I'm fine" and Gerald heard "I'm drowning."

BACK TO DANNY:

He stands at attention. The posture of a man trained to take whatever comes next.

For a moment, his eyes find Gerald's across the room. Father and son. A lifetime of missed connections. Of love expressed in casseroles and worry expressed in silence.

Danny's mouth opens.

We expect something. An explanation. A defense. The speech where the protagonist makes meaning of the chaos.

DANNY

No, ma'am.

Two words. That is all.

But they carry everything: acceptance, accountability, the end of fighting something that was never meant to be fought.

Commander Wells nods. She expected more. She got what she needed.

COMMANDER WELLS

Very well.

She turns to the bench. The JUDGE, face unseen, looms in the periphery of the frame.

COMMANDER WELLS (CONT'D)

(formal, reciting)

On the charges of fraudulent manipulation of court-mandated sobriety monitoring equipment, driving under the influence on federal property, and conduct unbecoming...

She continues, but the AUDIO FADES as we--

PUSH IN ON: Gerald's face.

His expression tells us everything. The sentence is severe. His boy is going away.

A single tear tracks down Gerald's weathered cheek. Margaret's grip tightens.

BACK TO: DANNY.

Standing at attention as the words wash over him. He does not flinch. He does not break. He simply... accepts.

This is what acceptance looks like. Not defeat. Not resignation. Clarity.

HARD CUT TO:

29 INT. NAVY JAG COURTROOM - MOMENTS LATER

29

The room empties. Shuffling feet. Murmured conversations.

Danny is led toward a side door by TWO SHORE PATROL OFFICERS.

He pauses. Turns back.

Gerald stands alone in the gallery. Margaret has stepped away, giving them this moment.

Father and son look at each other.

GERALD
(barely audible)
Danny--

DANNY
(cutting him off, gentle)
It's okay, Dad.

Beat.

DANNY (CONT'D)
I'm okay.

This time, when he says it, we believe him.

Danny turns. Walks through the door.

It closes behind him.

HOLD ON: Gerald. Standing alone in the empty courtroom.

Then--

HARD CUT TO:

A NEWSPAPER.

CLOSE ON: The headline, filling the frame.

"NAVY INVESTIGATES 'WILDLIFE
OVERRIDE' LOOPHOLE
IN BREATHALYZER SYSTEMS"

Below the headline: a small graphic. A RACCOON PAW PRINT, stylized, like a logo for the strangest scandal the military has ever seen.

The byline credits an investigation sparked by "the Vega incident."

FREEZE FRAME on the newspaper.

TITLE CARD (over the freeze frame):

Following the Vega case, the Navy overhauled breathalyzer interlock protocols across all installations.

The "Wildlife Override" loophole was closed.

Danny Vega was dishonorably discharged.
He now works as an addiction counselor
in San Diego.

He has been sober for three years.

The headline holds. A drunk legacy. Policy changed by the worst decision a man ever made.

FADE TO BLACK.

Silence.

Then--

Faint, almost imperceptible: the CHITTER of a raccoon.

30 EXT. ALLEY - DUMPSTER - NIGHT

30

A single sodium vapor light. A dumpster. The same cathedral glow.

TWO EYES catch the light from the darkness. Reflecting. Watching.

A pause.

Then the eyes disappear into shadow.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE END